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2022 Revised National Curriculum for primary, secondary and special schools announced

□ In December 22, the Ministry of Education (Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Education Lee Ju-Ho) announced the *2022 Revised National Curriculum,* which aims to cultivate students to develop into adults equipped with the sense of tolerance and creativity in line with what future societies demand.

Background

○ To support students to respond the future changes, the revision of the curriculum mainly focuses on the following four areas: 1) systematizing desirable learner competencies such as self-initiative and creativity; 2) operation of a flexible curriculum in schools across different regions; 3) student-tailored education; and 4) digital- and AI-based classroom education.

Progress

□ After announcing the 2022 Revised National Curriculum General Guidelines Draft last November, policy research was conducted (i.e. 45 tasks and 860 researchers), involving in-service teachers making up more than half

of all researchers, in a bid to make the general guidelines more responsive to the education being offered in the actual school settings.

※ **[2019-2020]** Basic research for developing future-oriented curriculum ⇒ **[2021]** Research to develop 2022 revised curriculum general guidelines and research on restructuring of six subject matters curriculum ⇒ **[1st half 2022]** Research on curriculum general guidelines draft development ⇒ **[2nd half 2022]** Development of teaching/learning and assessment methods for each subject matter

○ Public opinions were broadly collected by using various channels, including policy research discussion meeting (Apr.11-22), key teacher training program (Jul.18-Aug.11), forum with students and parents (Aug.5-27), and public hearing meeting (Sept.28-Oct.8), in order to design the curriculum to be adaptive to the actual classroom settings based on public participation for consensus.

○ Moreover, the committee for the preparation of the revised national curriculum (Apr.2021~; 21 members; 17 meetings) and committee on coordination of subject matter curriculum (Apr.2021~; 36 members ; six meetings) consisted not only of the experts from the education sector but also those from a whole host of sectors to reflect and coordinate various areas to improve the general guidelines wherever needed, for which the general public also participated via public participation channels* (1st: Aug. 30-Sep. 13; 2nd: Sept. 29- Oct. 13) to present their views freely online.

* The public participation channel was first introduced for the 2022 Revised National Curriculum to collect diverse opinions online.

○ In particular, when it comes to subject matters such as History, Health, Ethics, Social Studies and Music, the subject matter curriculum coordination committee (Sept. 21) and the revision committee (Sept. 26 and Oct. 20) as well as the curriculum deliberation committee were held to discuss in-depth controversial issues.

○ The final version of the 2022 Revised National Curriculum general guidelines was published after having gone through various processes, including collecting public opinion during the administrative notice period (Nov. 9-29), and the curriculum deliberation committee meetings were held to come up with a draft which then went through the Presidential

Committee on Education's deliberation and decision making (Dec. 14).

- Feedback received during the administrative notice period mostly ranged from gender-related expressions, use of the terms "liberal democracy" and "democracy," and improving the use of autonomous school hours. The following is how the Presidential Committee on Education has decided to revise for improvement.

> •**(General guidelines)** To delete the requirement to secure the maximum of 68 hours of school autonomous hours while only presenting the basic guidelines for the school autonomous hours
> •**(History)** To reflect requests to increase the content of premodern era in Korean History and added additional achievement standards in the premodern Korean history (the ancient times, Goryeo and Joseon)
> •**(Gender)** As for Health, the term "sexual/reproductive health and rights" is to be revised to "sexual health and rights," and in Technical and Home Economy, the term "trans-sexual" is to be deleted.

- Later, the following was produced as the final version by reflecting the feedback of the Presidential Committee on Education (Dec. 14).

> •**(Gender)** Deletion of wordings referring to sexuality; definition of sexual self-determination is clarified to supplement the guidelines on achievement standards
> •**(Being moral, laborious works, etc.)** Terms related to being moral, ethical and philosophical are revised to "the alignment with moral knowledge and practice," and guidelines for teaching/learning will include more clarified educational definition of laborious works, while deleting the examples of classroom instruction.

Major Revisions in General Guidelines

□ The 2022 Revised National Curriculum aims "to support students to grow into self-initiated talent with the sense of tolerance and creativity," fully equipped with the key skills demanded by future societies.

○ In order to realize this, the general guidelines for the revised curriculum states that the goal of the curriculum is to foster students to become self-initiated person and to highlight the importance of having an active attitude with initiative and responsibility. The most crucial quality of a highly desirable person, according to the current curriculum, is "an independent person," but it will be changed to "a self-initiated person" in

the new curriculum.

○ The general guidelines also underscores that "cooperative communication skills" should be pursued with the new curriculum to help students respond to changes in future societies.

□ The general guidelines emphasizes the following:

○ First, the curriculum should contribute to strengthening individual competency and basic skills to respond to future societies, and foster self-initiative attitude toward one's learning and life.

- The curriculum underscores the importance of basic skills such as literacy, numeracy, and digital skills as they lay the foundation for studying other wide-ranging subjects.

- In order to foster digital literacy, rationality and procedural problem-solving abilities, the revised curriculum now includes subjects reflecting basic digital skills to match distinctive features of different subjects and elective subjects.

○ Second, the curriculum should contribute to fostering student character and strengthening the sense of community to ensure the happiness of all.

- The curriculum should highlight an education that fosters responsive skills to help deal with climate and ecosystem changes, and community-based values such as sustainability.

- The curriculum should also ensure that students with distinctive qualifies are not discriminated, and to narrow the gap in education between different regions and schools by putting in place an appropriate system.

○ Third, students should be supported with a learner-tailored curriculum to be able to design their career and learning path in a self-motivated manner, and to learn at desirable time.

- School flex time will be introduced in the curriculum to allow schools to

offer elective subjects to match the needs of each student in connection with the regional community.

- The curriculum is designed in a way that is relevant to career education. For example, different levels of schools will ensure that their curricula are well connected with one another, and opportunities will be offered to students to allow them to design their future career and support their adjustment to school life.

○ Fourth, the curriculum will assist students' development of basic skills based their self-initiative.

- Study load will be adjusted to appropriate levels revolving around the key ideas that students must learn, and study materials will be streamlined to clarify what students should experience in the process of learning, exploration and problem-solving to improve teaching/learning and assessment methods.

□ The following is the major improvements made in the curriculum at all school levels.

○ As for the elementary school level, students will be supported to adjust to school at the beginning of the first and second year, and they will be given more chance to engage in learning Korean language and outside activities to stimulate physical movement.

- For example, for the first graders of elementary school, in order to help them better adapt to school, integrated subjects and creative experiential activities will make up daily school education, and 34 additional hours will be set aside for learning Korean to reinforce basic literacy skills.

- As for safety education for the first and second graders, the lesson hours will remain 64 hours, but integrated subjects will be reconstructed to ensure that it is offered in a practical manner by incorporating creative activities that match the developmental stages of students.

※ Students older than 3rd graders will be educated on how to stay safe in crowds, and how to respond

to emergency situations, thereby keeping the focus of safety education on practical hands-on activities.

- Moreover, students will be given more opportunities to move their body in ways that match their developmental stages as more content of their learning will be dedicated to physical activities.

○ At the middle school level, the timetable for the Free Semester (for the first graders of middle schools) will be adjusted* and the areas of activities, and school sports club activities will also be adjusted** to be better aligned with the revised curriculum.

* **[Before revision]** 4 areas of activity (thematic activity, career exploration, arts & sports, school club activities) 170 hours → **[After revision]** two areas of activity (thematic activity, career exploration) 102 hours

** **[Before revision]** 136 hours over 3 years (34-68 hours per year) → **[After revision]** 102 hours over 3 years (34 hours per year)

- Before advancing to high school, in the second semester of the 3rd year middle school, the classroom instruction will be aligned with career education so that students can better adapt to what they will learn in high school, which will also be linked to the Free Semester.

○ In high school, the curriculum will be restructured to incorporate elective subjects based on academic credits to allow students to study the subjects of their choosing and to earn credits accordingly.

- Generally, four credits will be given per subject (three credit points for sports, art and liberal art subjects) to allow students to freely choose to study subjects of their interest in alignment with their future career.

- The curriculum includes diverse elective subjects and integrated elective subjects to support learners to grow their critical reasoning, real-life problem-solving, writing and thematic classes that are in alignment with their future career interest and aptitude.

- The specialized subject I, which was only available in specialized high schools, are now also available in general high schools in the form of a general subject to that it can be selected in line with students' career

interest and aptitude.

- The curriculum of specialized vocational high schools is reconstructed to include an expanded range of specialized common subjects*, along with general major and practicum courses to better equip students with basic competency and key skills required in the world of work in the future.

* **[Before revision]** "Successful Vocational Life" → **[After revision]** "Successful Vocational Life"; "Labor Rights and Occupational Safety"; "Digital and Vocational Life"

Major Revisions in Curriculum

○ The overarching concept of in-depth learning, alignment of subjects, relevance of learning to real-life, and reflection of learning process are all included in the revised curriculum.

- The scope of learning content is adjusted to an appropriate level surrounding key ideas, and syllabuses within subject are well connected to help students perform in-depth learning in their daily life.

○ Furthermore, the revised curriculum emphasizes the initiative of learners as it enables them to recognize problems on their own and to seek ways to solve the problems on their own terms.

- Critical questioning, discussion and debate in the classroom, and collaborative learning are all included in the revised curriculum to improve school education in a bid to help students hone their learning skills that match their own pace.

- Not only what they learn, but also their interaction with peers and changes in thinking and behavior are all constantly evaluated to offer tailored feedback to students.

□ Major revisions are as follow:

○ In the case of Korean, lower graders (1st-2nd graders) of elementary school will study 34 more hours of Korean to raise their level of basic

literacy skills.

- The revised curriculum for Korean aims to allow students to learn accumulatively, taking into account that Korean language typically requires accumulative work to reach proficiency, thereby deepening the basic knowledge of students.

○ Elective subjects will become available to learn about media from as early as the primary school level. For example, elementary and middle schools will offer "Media" as an elective subject, whereas high school will provide "Literature and Video," and "Media Communication."

- Also, in high school, "Thematic Reading" and "Reading, Discussion and Writing" will be offered as new subjects to support students to be equipped with critical thinking and writing skills.

○ For mathematics, the mathematical skills of students will be fostered in the transitional period of digitalization by considering the appropriate study load for different grades and the subject syllabuses are restructured accordingly.

- New elective subjects are created in all elementary, middle and high school levels. For example, subject areas are integrated to ensure that subjects in elementary and middle schools are relevant. As for high school, various elective subjects are developed such as "Practical Statistics," "Mathematics and Culture," and "Practical Mathematics" in line with students' aptitude and career interest.

- Students will be encouraged to raise their interest and confidence in mathematics with mathematical modeling and play- and game-based learning to make teaching/learning and assessment models more concrete, and the use of engineering tools such as learning based on digital tools are more emphasized.

○ As for English, moving away from the previous categorizing method based on functions such as "listening," "speaking," "reading," it will be categorized into "understanding" and "expression."

- Academic achievement standards are designed considering student development and school levels, and English education is revised to put more emphasis on daily English communication skills closely relevant to student life.

- In high school, "General English" will foster basic English skills, and new courses are developed such as "Competency English" and English Presentation and Debate" to teach what students need in future career, and "Everyday English Speaking," "Media English," and "World Culture and English" to make better use of English in daily life.

○ As for social studies, study load will be adjusted to run inquiry-based classroom education, surrounding key ideas and considering different school levels.

- The often used expressions of "to understand" and "to explore" in the academic achievement standards outlined in the general guidelines will be more diversified so that rather than focusing on finding one answer, more emphasis will be put on the process of finding more than one answer in the classroom based on inquisitive and practice-based learning.

- Particularly in high school, "Politics and Law" will be separated into "Politics" and "Law and Society" to offer education in line with student career and aptitude, while "Global Citizen and Geography," "Future of Cities," "Finance and Economic Life" and "Climate Change and Sustainable World" to make a variety of subjects available for students.

○ As for Science, to advance scientific competency and creativity to allow students to respond to complicated problems of the future in a flexible manner by highlighting scientific competencies such as inquisitive and inferential abilities, integrative thinking skills and problem-solving skills so that students can make better use of them throughout their life.

- Elementary and middle schools will try to prevent fragmented teaching

with respect to different branches of Science such as Physics, Chemistry, Life Science, and Earth Science, and in line with student development levels, subject contents will be reorganized surrounding key ideas at different school levels such as climate change, communicable diseases and career, thereby expanding integrated chapters in each grade (e.g. 1→2).

* 【e.g.】 [3·4th grade] 'Communicable Diseases and Healthy Life', 'Climate Change and Our Life'
[5·6th grade] 'Resources and Energy', 'Science and My Career'

- Particularly in high school, "Integrated Science" will emphasize the basic scientific competency and integrated understanding, and a variety of new subjects will be created in relation to science, career and other integrated areas to advance scientific skills.

※ General elective (4 types), career elective (8 types), integrative elective (3 types), science elective (9 types)

○ Informatics education will be restructured to incorporate AI and big data to raise student understanding based on the current software education, and its lesson hours will be expanded in elementary and middle schools.

* (Elementary) home economics: 17 hours → +34 house / (Middle) Informatics 34 hours → + 68 hours

- Elementary school education will include activities of play and experiential learning, whereas middle school students will learn through simple computer programs on everyday problem-solving to help students learn basic skills without having to feel stress.

※ **[Elementary]** Unplugged activities such as playing card can help students understand problem-solving process, and block-based coding can be used for the actual learning of the process.

[Middle] Understanding of a series of computational thinking process and of values and attitudes such as AI ethics in everyday life.

- In addition, informatics can be used to help students find future career in line with their aptitudes by having diverse subjects available.

* General elective: 'Informatics' / career elective: ‘Basic AI’, ‘Data Science’ / integrative elective: ‘Software and Life’

○ Specialized vocational high schools will offer specialized subjects that are

restructured in consideration of the actual situation on industrial sites and changes through establishing base courses* in line with the integration of technologies.

* Base courses are newly created such as 'Software', 'Chemistry (bio)', 'Energy', 'Firefighting', 'Smart City' and 'Smart Factory'

Curriculum for Special Education

□ The 2022 Revised National Curriculum for special education aims for: 1) the outlining of the curriculum framework; 2) creating new programs for daily activity for students with severe level of disabilities; and 3) expanding support for the curriculum of inclusive education, emphasizing the need for a tailored curriculum taking into account the specific disability needs as well as their educational needs.

□ Key revisions in the general guidelines are as follows:

○ First, disabilities and educational needs will be considered to design a tailored curriculum, different from that of the past which mainly focused on providing an alternative education.

- The instructional hours of subjects, creative experiential activities and daily activities are allowed to be readjusted within the 50% requirement limit, an increase from the current limit of 30%.

- In addition, the curriculum will include daily activities to help students with severe disabilities to cope with the difficulties they face every day.

* Communication, independent living, physical activity, leisure activity and adaptive living, etc.

○ Second, educational support will be differentiated depending on what institutions the students study.

- **[General school]** Students with disabilities have greater access to the common curriculum through restructuring elementary and middle school curriculum and developing guidelines to allow the use of special education textbooks.

- **[Special school]** It's been made possible to use both the curriculum of

common and elective subjects and the basic curriculum to reflect educational demands of students with severe disabilities or sensory impairments.

- **[Itinerant education]** When developing curriculum and its guidelines at the level of city and provincial offices of education, educational needs of the students at the receiving end of itinerant education will be taken into consideration.

○ Third, subjects are newly created or revised with an aim to help students with disabilities better adapt to daily life and society after high school graduation by taking into consideration their educational demands and the type of their disabilities.

※ Creation of ‘Social Adaptation’ subject; In high school, ‘Independent Living of Visually Impaired' and ‘The life and culture of the hearing impaired’ are shifted from the creative experiential activities criteria to vocation and life criteria as elective subjects

□ The main revisions in the subject matter curriculum guidelines are as follows:

○ The general guidelines and subject matter guidelines will be more closely linked to maintain the consistency of the national curriculum while reflecting educational needs of students with disabilities and the type of their disabilities.

※ Matters to be considered when it comes to setting the achievement standard for students with severe level of disabilities will be presented, and the type of their disabilities and educational demands will also be considered in teaching/learning and assessment.

- The list of achievement standards will be reduced 20% compared to the current curriculum, and the content will also be readjusted to include more real-life content within a desirable level to reduce the study burden on students with severe levels of disabilities.

Plan Ahead

□ The 2022 Revised National Curriculum being announced this time will be introduced in 2024 for the first and second year students of elementary school, and in 2025 in middle and high schools.

○ With the announcement of the revised curriculum, the development of textbooks will also begin, and teacher training will be reinforced in line with the introduction of high school academic credit system and restructuring of subjects.

□ In addition, in a bid to prepare the college admission system in line with the newly revised curriculum, the opinions of high schools, colleges and experts around the country will be gathered to reflect on the plan for revising college admission in 2028 by February 2024.

□ Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Education Lee Ju-Ho said, "We'll open up a new chapter of education with the 2022 Revised National Curriculum to support all students to fulfill their potential and advance competency through various means."

○ He added, "Digital-based tailored education in line with individual students' learning pace and characteristics will guarantee them to meet the basic academic level, and instruction that focuses on student creativity and character, and innovating assessment to reinvigorate the education in the classroom."

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